■ EARLYDROP

EarlyDrop

Music Pre-Order & Discovery App

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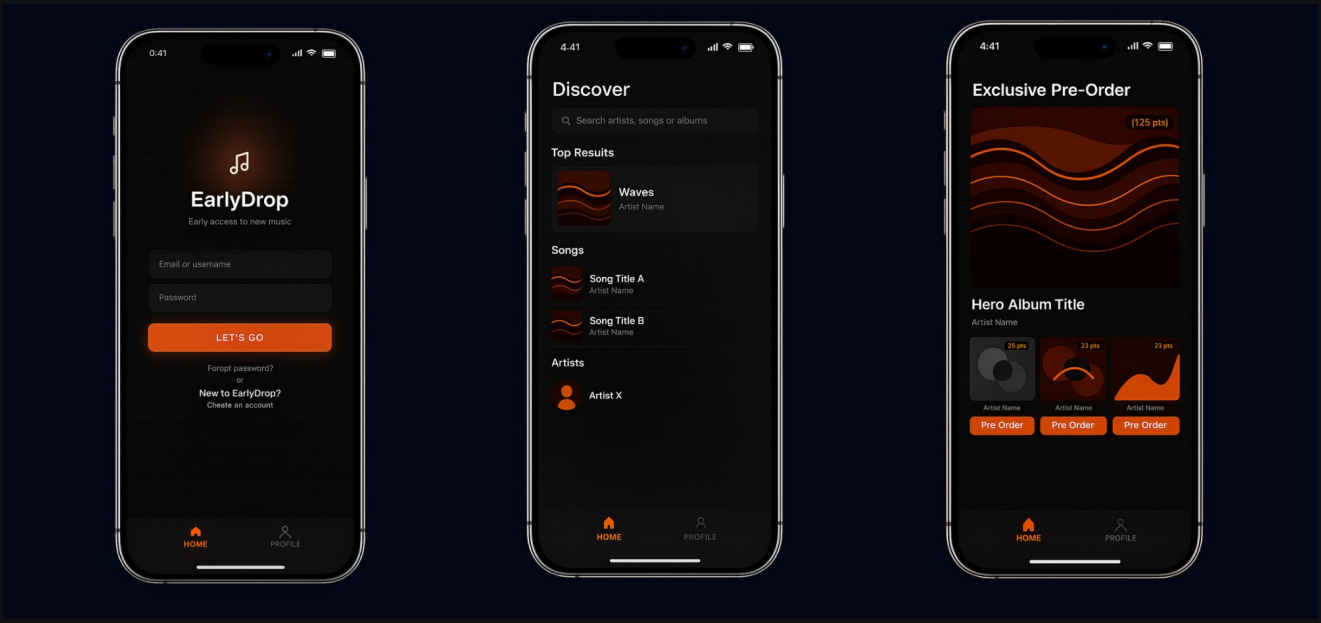
UX Researcher & Designer · Figma · Usability Testing

3 weeks · Personal Project · 2022



TL;DR

Music fans miss releases. Pre-orders are scattered across a dozen sites. There's no single place to stream early, pre-order vinyl or digital, and get rewarded for discovering new artists before anyone else. EarlyDrop is that place.

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THE CHALLENGE

The Problem

Music fans miss out on limited releases and can't discover new music before it hits mainstream platforms. There's no unified way to stream early, pre-order physical copies, and earn rewards — forcing users to juggle multiple apps and websites while risking sold-out albums.

THE SOLUTION

How EarlyDrop Fixes It

EarlyDrop gives fans exclusive early streaming access combined with seamless pre-ordering for vinyl, CDs, and digital downloads. A built-in rewards system encourages discovery and repeat purchases, while curated drops help users find new artists before anyone else.

KEY FEATURES

Early Streaming — Listen to new albums before public release — exclusive first access.

One-Tap Pre-Order — Seamless ordering for vinyl, CD, and digital with minimal clicks.

Reward Points — Earn points for every purchase, redeemable for discounts and exclusive merch.

Curated Discovery — Personalized recommendations and featured drops help users find new artists.

USER RESEARCH

Research Methodology

Conducted interviews and usability studies with 5 music enthusiasts (ages 18–35) who actively purchase physical albums and attend live shows regularly. Research focused on how fans discover new music, their album purchasing habits, and pain points with existing pre-order platforms.

Method — Unmoderated usability study — remote, participants in their own homes

Participants — 5 active music collectors and concert-goers, service industry workers

Duration — 10–15 minute sessions followed by a System Usability Scale questionnaire

Key Focus Areas — Music discovery, pre-ordering flow, payment, early streaming access

KPIs — Time on task, user error rates, conversion rates

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

– How long does it take a user to find music they like?

– What steps does a user take to find and order music, and what can we learn from them?

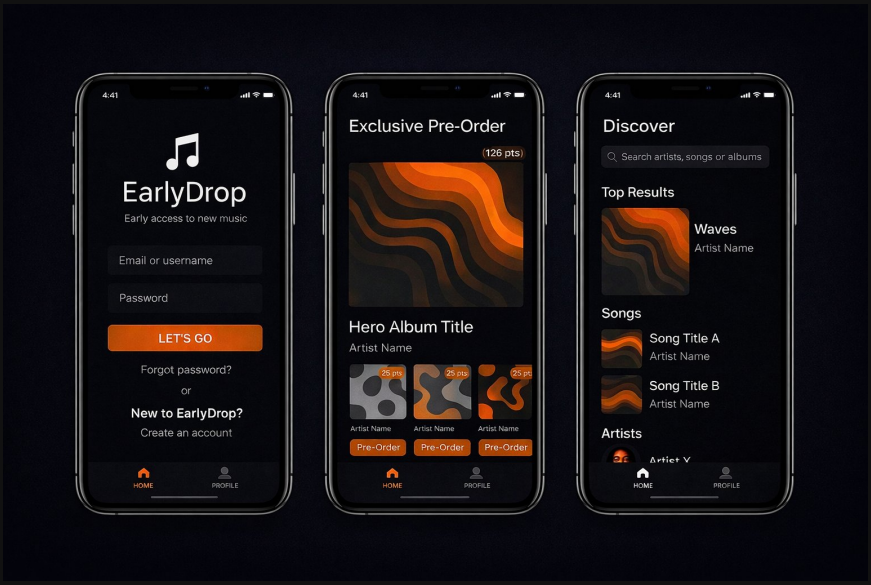
– Where are users running into problems within the app?

– What design changes can solve those problems?

DESIGN PROCESS

From Lo-Fi to Hi-Fi

The design started with a simple login and onboarding flow — minimal friction to get users into the app and browsing new releases immediately. The core screens were: Login/Onboarding, Exclusive Pre-Order home, and Discover/Search.



Hi-fidelity mockups — Login, Exclusive Pre-Order, and Discover screens.

DESIGN DECISIONS

Dark theme with orange accents — Feels premium and music-native. High contrast for readability in low-light environments like concert venues.

Reward points always visible — Prominent display of points earned increased engagement and encouraged repeat purchases in testing.

Bottom nav kept minimal — Home and Profile only. Music browsing doesn't need deep nav — keep the focus on discovery.

One-tap Pre-Order buttons — Reduced friction at the decision point. Users got to checkout faster with fewer steps.

USABILITY FINDINGS

What Testing Revealed

Checkout completed fast — Participants completed orders in under 2 minutes with minimal errors.

Navigation was clear — Users browsed, searched, and added items to cart without confusion.

Reward points drove engagement — Prominent display increased interaction and repeat purchase intent.

High satisfaction overall — Most participants rated the app easy and enjoyable to use.

NEXT STEPS

Where EarlyDrop Goes Next

– Refine UI based on updated design trends and accessibility standards

– Add social sharing so users can share new discoveries with their network

– Integrate artist profiles with exclusive content — interviews, behind-the-scenes

– Build partnerships with indie labels for exclusive early drops

– Explore a React Native mobile build to take the prototype to a real app

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"The goal was simple — build the app I wish existed the first time I tried to pre-order a record."

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